the dispute I hoped we'd just seen the back of, had made the manager believe I was up and down the highway every other day. He wasn't annoyed with me for the sake of it—I knew that—but because he genuinely believed the life I led away from soccer was interfering with what really mattered: winning games for United. And nothing I could say could convince him he was wrong. I could do something, though, to try and set things straight: play.

We were flying. The World Club Championship had been a break from the intensity of the Premiership and I think we came back feeling really strong. I won my place in the team back after the Leeds game and, between then and the end of the season, we drew two games and won the rest in the League. We finished champions, 18 points ahead of Arsenal, and the gap at the top said it all. We'd only lost three games all year and nobody else had been able to live with that. The season's one disappointment was that we didn't defend the Champions League either. Our experience in Europe meant we'd learned how to get through the group phase even if we lost the odd game or didn't play at our best in others. Once you get to the knockout stages, though, it's different: real cup soccer and against some of the best teams in the world. In the quarter-finals in 2000, we were drawn against Real Madrid.

The first leg at the Santiago Bernabeu, we drew 0–0. They played some great soccer but we had the chances to win—you always get chances against Real—and played well. An away goal that night in Spain would have made all the difference. As it was we were really looking forward to getting them back to Old Trafford. We thought we could beat them. So did our supporters. So did the press. Real Madrid didn't. This was before the days of Zidane, Figo and Ronaldo but Real had great players—I think the boss said he thinks that Raul is the best there is anywhere in the world—and they scored great goals in Manchester and beat us before we really got going. There was no shame in losing to them. They went on to win the competition after all. But we were shattered. We had our chances but didn't take them.

It was a little like the first half of our game in Madrid in 2003: they had this spell, for fifteen minutes after half-time at Old Trafford, when everything they did seemed to come off and we couldn't get near them. I remember their left-sided midfield player, Redondo, the Argentinian, did this unbelievable dragback to take the ball past Henning Berg. He crossed and Raul just had a tap-in. It was brilliant. We'd lost one goal in the first half, then Raul got his two and, before even an hour of the game had gone—a game that we'd never felt out of—we were 3–0 down. We came back in the last half hour: I scored, Scholesy got a penalty, but they held on and we were out.